The Living Project Whitepaper

Version 3.0.3

Executive summary

The Living Project is a model-agnostic framework and installable CLI for AI-assisted project work. It combines a one-line public installer, a structured workspace, an optional Codex skill, and an upgrade model that preserves user work while refreshing managed framework files.

Live public package

@the-living-project/the-living-project-cli

Install command: npx -y @the-living-project/the-living-project-cli init

The problem this solves

- **Teams often start with deliverables instead of the real problem.**

Context is incomplete or never carried forward cleanly.

- **First drafts are over-trusted and under-reviewed.**

Scope drift is recognized too late.

- **Abandoned work rarely becomes reusable insight.**
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- ## Framework design
- The Living Project uses a seven-phase model: SEED, NOURISH, GROW, PRUNE, REPOT, COMPOST, and CULTIVATE. The core loop is SEED to NOURISH to GROW to PRUNE, repeating until the output is ready to ship or hand off.
- ## Phase guidance

• Phase	• What to do	• Prompt guidance
• SEED	• Clarify the real problem, root need, audience, and urgency.	• Ask for root-cause analysis, a structured seed statement, key assumptions, and likely blind spots.
• NOURISH	• Load context from notes, documents, constraints, and prior work.	• Ask for a context inventory, contradictions, and the questions a domain expert would still need answered.
• GROW	• Generate one or more directional outputs and iterate.	• Ask for multiple approaches, clear tradeoffs, and regeneration based on what

		should change and what should stay.
• PRUNE	• Critique and improve the work against the original goal.	• Ask for gaps, redundancies, logic issues, risks, a score, and a repaired version.
• REPOT	• Re-evaluate the shape of the project when the current container is too small.	• Ask for a pros and cons analysis across constraining, expanding, or splitting the effort.
• COMPOST	• Extract value from a stalled or completed direction.	• Ask for validated assumptions, invalidated assumptions, reusable components, and a stronger restart brief.
• CULTIVATE	• Step back and manage multiple active efforts as a portfolio.	• Ask for risk review, dependencies, cross-pollination opportunities, and recommendations for where attention should go next. •

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- **Product architecture**

1. **Public npm package for distribution.**

CLI runtime for init, upgrade, and doctor.

2. **Workspace payload under .living-project.**

Optional Codex skill support through the living-project skill.

Workspace contract

- **START-HERE.md is the visible first-run handoff.**

.living-project\seeds stores seed statements.

- **.living-project\context stores context briefs and working memory.**

.living-project\phases stores reusable guidance for the framework.

- **.living-project\compost stores post-mortems and extracted learnings.**

.living-project\cultivate-log.md tracks portfolio and weekly review.

Current release state

- **GitHub repository is live and is the source of truth.**

Public npm package is published.

- **Trusted publishing is configured through GitHub Actions.**

CI validates package behavior on main and pull requests.

- **The one-line install command is tested and working.**
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- ## Release model
- Standard tag format: living-project-vX.Y.Z
- Tagged releases publish through GitHub Actions with npm trusted publishing.
- ## Conclusion
- The Living Project has moved from concept to working product: a public package, a working installer, a structured workspace framework, and an upgradeable operating model for AI-assisted project work.
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